

# Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 13

**Time allowed:** 1 hour 50 minutes

**Total marks for Sections B and C:** 45

## Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [ ] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

## Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

**Text 3:** A primary-school boy finds a wounded sparrow during recess and tries to save it without being seen by a teacher he distrusts.

**1**

The bell for recess had only just gone when I saw it, lying on its side at the edge of the school field where the grass met the bare red earth. At first I thought it was a leaf, or one of those crumpled bits of paper that boys throw at one another when no one is looking. Then the leaf moved — a small, uneven shudder — and I knew, with a quick clutch in my stomach, that it was alive.

**2**

It was a sparrow, no bigger than my closed fist. One wing lay open on the dust at a wrong, terrible angle, as if a careless hand had unfolded it and forgotten to fold it back. Its eye, which was the colour of a wet seed, looked at me without blinking. I crouched down in my white school shoes, suddenly aware of how loud my own breathing was. The other boys were already halfway to the canteen and I could hear them shouting about chicken rice. None of them had seen.

**3**

I should, I knew, have told a teacher. That was what the posters at the back of the classroom said: **In an emergency, tell a teacher.** But the only teacher on duty that morning was Mr Tham, who had once shouted at me for ten minutes for kicking a ball into his flowers, and who, I was sure, did not like small, frightened things. He would, I thought, pick the sparrow up by one wing and drop it into the bin behind the tuckshop, and that would be that. I made up my mind, in the quick, fierce way that children do, that I would not let this happen.

**4**

I took off my PE shirt — the spare one I kept rolled in my bag — and made it into a kind of nest in my cupped hands. The sparrow weighed almost nothing. It was warm. I had not expected it to be so warm. I walked, very slowly and very straight, towards the bicycle shed at the far end of the field, where no one ever went during recess because the metal roof made it as hot as an oven. There, behind a stack of

old chairs, I laid the bird down. Its chest rose and fell, rose and fell, in a quick, frightened rhythm, and I knew that I had to do something but I did not know what.

5

“Eh, what are you doing?” A voice behind me. I jumped so badly that I nearly stepped on the bird. It was Wei Lun, from Primary Six, who was supposed to be a prefect but was always sneaking off behind the bicycle shed himself. He saw the sparrow before I could think of a lie, and his face, which I had only ever seen looking bored, became suddenly serious. He knelt down beside me without saying anything for a long time. Then he said, very quietly, “Cardboard box. Soft cloth. No water — it will breathe it in.” He was not asking me. He was telling me what to do.

6

Wei Lun, it turned out, kept a shoebox in his locker for reasons of his own. He brought it, lined it with the inside of his own jumper, and showed me how to lift the bird with two fingers under its chest, the way a person lifts something that might break. We sat in the heat of the bicycle shed for the rest of recess. Wei Lun did not talk much. Once he said, “It’s a young one. See, the feathers.” Once he said, “The wing is bad.” That was all. I felt, sitting next to him, both very small and very grown up, the way one does in the presence of a person who knows things one does not.

7

We brought the box to the school office after the bell, and the office aunty, who was usually frightening, called a man from a wildlife place who came in a green van. He looked at the bird for less than a minute. Then he looked at me, and at Wei Lun, with a kind, tired expression I did not yet have a word for. He said the wing was broken in two places, and that they would try, but that I should not, perhaps, expect too much. He used the word **perhaps** very gently. I understood, then, for the first time, that there were some things a boy could not save, no matter how carefully he carried them, and no matter how quietly he kept them out of Mr Tham’s sight.

8

The man from the green van never told me what happened to the sparrow. Perhaps he was being kind. Wei Lun graduated at the end of that year and I did not see him again. But the warmth of a small, frightened weight in my hands — the surprise of it, the seriousness of it — has stayed with me for a long time. I think sometimes that it was the first day I understood that to care for something is not, by itself, enough to keep it alive, and that this realisation, painful as it was, was its own kind of beginning.

### From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says he felt “a quick clutch in my stomach” when he realised the leaf was alive. Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about his feelings at that moment. [2]

### From Paragraph 2

2. The narrator describes the sparrow’s wing as lying “at a wrong, terrible angle, as if a careless hand had unfolded it and forgotten to fold it back.” Explain how this comparison makes the bird’s injury seem more disturbing. [2]

3. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 2 that shows the other boys were unaware of the sparrow. [1]

### From Paragraph 3

4. In your own words, explain **two** reasons why the narrator decides **not** to tell Mr Tham about the sparrow. [2]

**From Paragraph 4**

5. The narrator writes that “the sparrow weighed almost nothing. It was warm. I had not expected it to be so warm.”

- (a) What is the effect of using three short sentences here? [1]  
(b) Why might the warmth of the bird have come as a surprise to him? [1]

**From Paragraph 5**

6. Wei Lun’s face, “which I had only ever seen looking bored, became suddenly serious.” What does this **contrast** suggest about Wei Lun’s character? [2]

7. The narrator writes: “He was not asking me. He was telling me what to do.” Explain how this short, two-sentence structure adds **emphasis** to Wei Lun’s behaviour. [2]

**From Paragraph 6**

8. The narrator says he felt “both very small and very grown up” sitting next to Wei Lun. Explain, in your own words, what he means by this. [2]

**From Paragraph 7**

9. The man from the green van “used the word **perhaps** very gently.” What does the writer suggest by drawing attention to **one single word** in this way? [2]

**From Paragraph 8**

10. What impression do you form of the narrator looking back as an adult? Support your answer with **one** detail from Paragraph 8. [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

**Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**

**Text 4: A feature article on plastic pollution in the deep ocean and the difficulty of cleaning it up.**

**1**

For most of the twentieth century, the deep ocean was imagined, by those who imagined it at all, as a kind of last wilderness — a cold, black, untouchable place beyond the reach of human carelessness. That illusion has, in the last decade, been quietly demolished. In 2018, researchers descending to the Mariana Trench, the deepest known point on Earth, recovered a plastic bag at a depth of almost eleven thousand metres. Two years later, scientists studying the stomachs of deep-sea amphipods — tiny, shrimp-like creatures that have never seen daylight — found microplastic fibres in every single specimen they dissected. The wilderness, it turns out, had been receiving our rubbish for some time.

**2**

How plastic arrives in such places is, in itself, a quiet indictment of how we have lived. Some of it sinks directly, dragged down by currents, biofilms, or the weight of marine snow — the perpetual drift of organic particles that falls from the upper ocean to the seabed like a slow, dark blizzard. Some of it travels inside the bodies of fish and crustaceans that swallow it nearer the surface and are themselves eaten, or that die and sink. A great deal of it begins life on land, as a plastic bottle dropped on a beach in one country, a fishing net abandoned in another, a tyre worn down on a motorway a thousand miles inland. The ocean, in the end, is the lowest point of every drain on the planet.

**3**

What makes the deep-sea problem so peculiarly difficult is not merely the **amount** of plastic but its **location**. Surface debris — the bottles and bags that drift in the well-photographed garbage patches of the Pacific — can at least be tracked from satellites and scooped up by ships. Microplastics in the sediment of an abyssal trench cannot. They lie, in many cases, kilometres below any practical recovery vessel, scattered across an area roughly the size of a continent, mixed in with sand and the bones of dead animals. Even if the engineering existed to retrieve them, the act of doing so would almost certainly disturb the very ecosystems one was trying to protect.

**4**

Nor is the chemistry encouraging. Plastic in the deep sea does not, as people often hope, “biodegrade”. It fragments — slowly, under pressure — into ever smaller pieces, releasing additives such as plasticisers and flame retardants as it goes. These substances are taken up by the smallest organisms, and from there move **up** the food chain: from amphipod to fish, from fish to seal, from seal, eventually, to us. A 2023 study from the Scripps Institution of Oceanography reported measurable concentrations of plastic-derived chemicals in the tissue of every commercially fished species it examined. The deep ocean, in other words, is no longer “away”.

**5**

International responses have begun, belatedly, to catch up. Negotiations for a United Nations Global Plastics Treaty, launched in 2022, aim to set binding targets on plastic production, design, and waste management across all member states. The High Seas Treaty, agreed in 2023, opens the legal door to marine protected areas in international waters — waters that previously belonged, in effect, to no one and were therefore protected by no one. These instruments are imperfect: their targets are contested, their timetables long, and the willingness of major plastic-producing economies to bind themselves uncertain. Yet they represent the first serious admission, at the international level, that the deep sea is **ours** to ruin and therefore **ours** to defend.

**6**

There is a familiar temptation, at this point, to retreat into individual virtue. Use a metal straw. Refuse

the plastic bag. Sort the recycling carefully. None of these acts is wrong, and a person who does them ought not to be sneered at. But a clear-eyed reading of the figures suggests that individual consumer choices, on their own, will not be enough. Roughly half of all plastic ever produced has been manufactured in the last two decades; production is forecast to **double** again by 2040. Against numbers of that order, the difference made by one household's metal straws is, frankly, small. The systemic problem requires systemic solutions — changes to how plastic is designed, taxed, produced, and disposed of, at a scale no individual shopper can achieve.

### 7

This does not mean individuals are powerless. It means that the most useful thing a thoughtful citizen can do may be less to police her own bin than to push her government, her supermarket, and her workplace into doing what only they can do. The plastic bag in the Mariana Trench did not arrive there by accident; it arrived through a long chain of choices made far above. The good news, if it can be called that, is that every link in that chain — design, sale, use, disposal — can be redesigned. The bad news is that the redesign must be done quickly, by people who are mostly comfortable, on behalf of creatures most of them will never see.

### From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says the deep ocean was once imagined as “a kind of last wilderness.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggested about how people used to view it. [2]

13. Why does the writer mention that microplastic fibres were found “in every single specimen” of the deep-sea amphipods? [2]

### From Paragraph 2

14. Marine snow is described as “a slow, dark blizzard.” What does this comparison suggest about how plastic reaches the seabed? [2]

15. In your own words, give **two** different ways, according to Paragraph 2, in which plastic from land ends up in the deep ocean. [2]

### From Paragraph 3

16. The writer states that the deep-sea problem is difficult because of “not merely the **amount** of plastic but its **location**.” Explain, in your own words, why the **location** makes the problem so difficult. [2]

### From Paragraph 4

17. The writer puts the word “biodegrade” in inverted commas. Why? [1]

18. The writer ends Paragraph 4 with the sentence: “The deep ocean, in other words, is no longer ‘away’.” What is the **effect** of this short closing sentence? [2]

### From Paragraph 5

19. The writer describes international treaties as “imperfect” but also as a “serious admission.”

- (a) Give **one** reason from Paragraph 5 why the treaties are **imperfect**. [1]
- (b) What does the writer mean by calling them a “serious admission”? [1]

**From Paragraph 6**

**20.** The writer says that a person who uses a metal straw “ought not to be sneered at.” What does this suggest about the writer’s **attitude** towards individual action? [2]

**From Paragraph 7**

**21.** The writer says the plastic bag in the Mariana Trench “did not arrive there by accident; it arrived through a long chain of choices made far above.” What is **effective** about this contrast? [2]

**22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]**

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why plastic pollution in the deep ocean is so hard to deal with**, and **what is being done about it at an international level**, as described in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

**Deep-sea plastic pollution is hard to deal with because ...**

— END OF PAPER —